Opening

By Matthew Kelty

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *The year is 1939 and Loew's Grand Theater in Atlanta, Georgia, has been selected as the site for the premiere of* Gone with the Wind.
ACTRESS: *As the date of the premiere approaches, all the black actors are notified that they have been barred from attending.*
ACTOR: *Ads depicting black actors are also forbidden under the Jim Crow laws.*
ACTRESS: *This selection shows the complex dynamic between one of the supporting actress of the film, Hattie McDaniel . . .*
ACTOR: *(Who went on to become the first black actress to win an Oscar for her role in the Gone with the Wind)*
ACTRESS: *. . . and David Selznick. the producer, as he makes Hattie aware of the restrictions that have been placed on the . . .*
TOGETHER: *Opening by Matthew Kelty*

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(Lights fade up. DAVID O. SELZNICK sits behind a large desk in his studio office, rubbing his forehead with his fingertips. After a moment, he presses a button on his intercom.')

SELZNICK: Sally, could you send Miss McDaniel in, please? *(A moment passes. HATTIE McDANIEL enters the office, dressed for a business meeting. She waits for SELZNICK to speak.)* Good morning, Hattie.

McDANIEL: Good morning, Mr Selnick.

SELZNICK: Hattie. David. Please.

McDANIEL: Morning, David.

SELZNICK: How are you today?

McDANIEL: I'm fine.

SELZNICK: Good. Good. *(Small pause.)* I... Listen, Hattie, I just want to thank you again for your wonderful work on the film.

McDANIEL: Thank you, Mr. Selzuick.

SELZNICK: David.

McDANIEL: Thank you, David.

SELZNICK: I mean, you're practically a co-star in the film - not really supporting at all.

McDANIEL: I'm glad you're pleased. Did you ask me to come in today so that you could thank me for my work?

SELZNICK: Yes.

McDANIEL: *(Turning to leave:)* Well, then. ..

SELZNICK: I mean, that wasn't the only reason, but yes, I... *(As McDANIEL turns back to him:)* I... Yes, I wanted to thank you. *(Small pause.)* You're wondering why we're here.

McDANIEL: I think I know, to tell the truth.

SELZNICK: You know.

McDANIEL: I think that I do. *(Pause.)*

SELZNICK: Well then for God's sake don't make me

McDANIEL: I'm just hoping that I'm wrong.

SELZNICK: Hattie ...

McDANIEL: *(Continuing:)* I mean, I'm praying that I'm wrong.

SELZNICK: This isn't something we can

McDANIEL: Why am I here today, Mr. Selznick? *(Pause.)*

SELZNICK: I've been talking to one of our boys down in Atlanta. *(No response.)* There's been a problem with the programs for the premiere. *(No response.)* Some of the people - at the theatre and at the print house - they were unhappy with your picture. Unhappy that it was there. They didn't think it would be appropriate for you and Butterfly to be on the cover of the program.

McDANIEL: Are we inside the program?

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SELZNICK: We're working on that. Certainly, you'll be on the programs in Los Angeles, New York ... It's just in Atlanta. *(Small pause.)*

McDANIEL: Well, thank you for asking me. *(Turning to go:)* I don't know what Butterfly will say, but if you need to take my-

SELZNICK: Hattie, stop. *(McDANIEL turns back around.)* Please. Just let me finish. Let me say what I have to say. *(She stares at him and waits.)* We've been talking with the theatre, trying to determine where the cast will sit, where they'll enter. *(Small pause.)* They've told us that the theatre ... It's segregated. The black actors won't be seated with the rest of the cast. You'll have to enter and exit separately, use separate restrooms - it's crazy, I know, it's ridiculous, but... The restaurant, too. The banquet before the premiere. They won't serve you. *(Small pause.)* You already know all of this.

McDANIEL: It's Hollywood, David. People talk. *(Small pause.)*

SELZNICK: I don't want to see you treated badly, Hattie.

McDANIEL: Then don't let them treat me badly, David.

SELZNICK: I think it's just best for everyone involved if –

McDANIEL: Everyone?

SELZNICK: Yes, everyone, if you don't attend the premiere.

McDANIEL: How would that be better for me?

SELZNICK: Do you really want to be turned away at the door, Hattie? With all the press there watching? That's embarrassing for us, humiliating for you -

McDANIEL: They wouldn't do it. Not with people taking pictures.

SELZNICK: They're already making us change the program.

McDANIEL: You could tell them, just tell them. They'd let me in.

SELZNICK: And the public would stream out the doors, while the cameras

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snapped. We've sunk a lot of money into this movie; we can't have people running out of the premiere. It'll be in every paper in the country. *(Pause.)*

McDANIEL: *(With mock sincerity:)* Maybe I could go, and then leave once we get to the theatre.

SELZNICK: I don't see that that's going to -

McDANIEL: *(Continuing, over SELZNICK, allowing the sarcasm to show:)* You know, just so Vivienne can have someone to carry her things. I've got a really nice kerchief I could wrap around my head that's not too worn ...

SELZNICK: Hattie, I don't know what else to do.

McDANIEL: Move the premiere. Why does Atlanta get to have the premiere if they're going to treat your actors so badly?

SELZNICK: Half the movie takes place in Atlanta.

McDANIEL: Half *The Wizard of Oz* takes place over the rainbow, but they didn't put little Judy Garland in a hot air balloon and send her -

SELZNICK: We can't move the premiere. We've already announced it, gotten so far along in the planning. If we move it, it'll be a scandal.

McDANIEL: And it won't be a scandal if your black actors don't go to the premiere? *(Small pause.)*

SELZNICK: Not to as many people, no. *(Pause.)*

McDANIEL: Well, I guess I didn't know why you called me in here after all. I thought you wanted to talk about how to handle Atlanta, but instead you just called me in to give me an order about -

SELZNICK: Well, the publicity boys actually think we've come up with something that ... *(Small pause.)* You know that I appreciate the ... It's a wonderful performance you gave us in this movie, Hattie.

McDANIEL: You said that earlier, yes.

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SELZNICK: It's really very fine.

McDANIEL: Thank you.

SELZNICK: I think it's deserving of recognition. From the Academy. I'd like to recommend you for consideration for Best Supporting Actress after we open. *(Small pause.)*

McDANIEL: Thank you, Mr. Selnick.

SELZNICK: David, please.

McDANIEL: David.

SELZNICK: Hattie. I'd like for you to write me a letter.

McDANIEL: About the nomination? I didn't know you needed a-

SELZNICK: I'd like for you to write me a letter saying that you have a previous commitment, and won't be able to attend the premiere in Atlanta.

McDANIEL: And the one is dependent on the other?

SELZNICK: I've really tried to work with you on this movie, Hattie.

McDANIEL: Oh?

SELZNICK: You wanted us to take "nigger" out of the script, we took it out.

McDANIEL: And left in "darkies." You wanted to leave in "nigger."

SELZNICK: It's a historical document, Hattie.

McDANIEL: It's a movie.

SELZNICK: Still, you wanted it out, and I took it out.

McDANIEL: And you did that just for me? That's so sweet, David. It didn't have anything to do with Butterfly and Oscar coming to you and -

SELZNICK: You sent them over.

McDANIEL: *(Continuing:)* - or the Hayes Commission or the editorials in the Negro papers protesting you even turning this book into a -

SELZNICK: I am trying to give you a way out of this. Trying to find a graceful way for us to handle this. The premiere is in Atlanta. The theater is

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segregated. We want to avoid a scandal. If you would just write me a letter saying that you have prior commitments, then -

McDANIEL: Then they win.

SELZNICK: Yes. Yes, they do win. You're right. And I hate to see it. But maybe you win, Hattie, injust a few months. Maybe they win that night, but you win at the Awards in the Spring. The first Negro to win an Academy Award, Hattie. Wouldn't that be something?

McDANIEL: You keep bringing those things up together.

SELZNICK: You said it yourself, Hattie. This is Hollywood. People talk.

McDANIEL: Talk about what?

SELZNICK: All kinds of things besides someone's performance. Like whether they're a team player, whether people would want to work with them again. A good role, that's only half of it. Maybe less.

McDANIEL: You're saying I won't win if I make a fuss about this.

SELZNICK: I'm saying you won't work again. *(Small pause.)*

McDANIEL: I think that's a little extreme. *(Small pause.)* You'd ruin my career because I won't write you a letter.

SELZNICK: There are plenty of colored actors in this town who want to work.

McDANIEL: And not enough roles as slaves and mammies to go around.

SELZNICK: What's that quote you gave in that interview, Hattie? Something ... "I've worked as a maid in real life ... The money's better in Hollywood." Something.

McDANIEL: I said I'd rather play a maid than work as one.

SELZNICK: Words to live by. *(Small pause.)* It's going to get better, Hattie. It'll just take some time. Make sure you're around for when it gets better. *(McDANIEL doesn't answer. SELZNICK turns to a stack of papers on his desk and begins to shuffle through them.)* Good, good, terrific. Now,

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I'm going to call one of the boys in from publicity to work with you on the letter. We'll keep it nice and simple, short, nothing we could get caught -

McDANIEL: But David, what if we -

(SELZNICK throws his papers onto the desk in frustration; they scatter all over the desk and the floor.)

SELZNICK: All right, I've had enough. I'm going to get someone to work with you on this. I'll be back in five minutes. If you're here, you're going to have a signed letter on my desk before you go home. If you're not here, don't bother coming back. Do you understand?

(He gets up and leaves without waiting for an answer. McDANIEL looks around the office for several moments. Some of the paper has fallen at her feet; she picks it up and puts it on the desk She looks around some more, then picks up some of the other paj)ers that have fallen. As she places them on the desk, her voice is heard reading the text of McDANIEL S letter to SELZNICK: The voice continues as she straightens the papers on the desk, and then possibly begins to straighten the office a little. She cleans as the voice continues and the lights begin to fade.)

McDANIEL'S VOICE: Dear Mr. Selznick: Thank you so much for your invitation to attend the world premiere of the studio's new film, *Gone with the Wind,* in Atlanta next month. I am thrilled to be a part of the film, and hope that the premiere goes well. Unfortunately, I will be unable to attend the premiere, due to circumstances that I'm unable to change. Best of luck in Atlanta. Please accept my apologies. And my deep, deep regrets.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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